Kewaskum police won't renew Flock Safety contract after license plate camera is stolen, amid public pushback

Police Chief Tom Bishop says public pushback across Washington County led his department to pause on the AI license plate-reading technology.

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Police Chief John Bishop says public pushback across Washington County led his department to pause on the AI license plate-reading technology.




By: Marcus Aarsvold

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KEWASKUM, Wis. — Kewaskum police will not renew their contract with Flock Safety, the department's police chief said, after an AI license plate-reading camera in the village was cut down and stolen earlier this year.

Back in July, someone knocked down and stole the one Flock Safety camera that was up in Kewaskum on Highway 45 and Highway H.



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Police Chief Tom Bishop said that since there has been so much public pushback in Germantown, Slinger and Hartford, his team opted not to replace the stolen camera or renew their contract with Flock.

Donald Williams, who owns a business nearby in Kewaskum, said he's glad the camera is gone.

"Because I think it's an invasion of privacy," he said. "They have the potential to be more invasive than the good."



Marcus Aarsvold

Donald Williams is a business owner in Kewaskum

Williams said he understands the cameras have helped law enforcement catch criminals, but he also worries they could be used maliciously.

Williams appreciates the police for pausing on a contract renewal, but he also said he wants to see more transparency.

"How come they have to be so reactive? Why can't they be more proactive? Why weren't we notified that this is a system that's in use?" Williams said. "I guess I wish policing were a little more upfront than secretive."

The decision might not be permanent. Bishop emailed TMJ4 News and said that he'll continue to monitor how these discussions evolve and may revisit the technology in the future. Until then, he said a pause is appropriate.



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